MARKET RESEARCH, DEMYSTIFIED

# The Marketing Research Process

*Eight steps that turn a business question into a confident, data-backed decision — illustrated with a running example: should a smartphone brand launch a new foldable phone?*

## WHY IT MATTERS

### THE THROUGH-LINE EXAMPLE

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**A smartphone company is deciding whether to launch a foldable phone.**

*Decision problem: launch or not? → Research problem: will the market accept a foldable phone at this price?*

1. Define the research problem
2. Determine research design
3. Identify data types & sources
4. Design data collection forms
5. Determine sampling design & size
6. Collect the data
7. Analyze & interpret the data
8. Prepare the research report

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## DEFINE THE RESEARCH PROBLEM

**A problem well defined is half-solved**

**EXAMPLE**

**Decision problem**

*"Should we launch a foldable phone?"*

**Research problem**

*"Will target buyers accept a foldable phone at our planned price point?"*

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## DETERMINE RESEARCH DESIGN

# Three lenses for one research problem

### Exploratory

**EXAMPLE**

*Talking to tech reviewers about foldable-phone durability concerns.*

### Descriptive

**EXAMPLE**

*Surveying 1,000 smartphone owners on brand-switching habits.*

### Causal

**EXAMPLE**

*A/B testing two price points in different regions to see which drives more pre-orders.*

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## IDENTIFY DATA TYPES & SOURCES

**Check what already exists before collecting new data**

### SECONDARY DATA

*Already collected — for this or another purpose*

**Internal:** sales invoices, warranty cards

**External:** published reports, census data, commercial data

**+ Faster and cheaper**

− May not fit the problem exactly; accuracy is harder to verify

### PRIMARY DATA

*Originated specifically for this study*

Demographics · psychographics · attitudes & opinions · awareness · purchase intentions · motivation · actual behavior

Gathered by communication (asking) or observation (watching). Observation is slower to arrange but typically more accurate than what people report about themselves.

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## DESIGN DATA COLLECTION FORMS

# Observe it, or ask about it

### Observational

An observer records behavior faithfully, without involving the respondent. Data is non-reactive, but can't capture attitudes or motives.

**EXAMPLE**

*Watching how shoppers actually hold and unfold a demo phone in-store.*

### Surveys

The most common way to collect primary data — always via a carefully tested, structured questionnaire.

**Personal**

In-depth interviews; richest detail, but interviewer bias can creep in.

*In-store demo interviews with early adopters.*

**Telephonic**

Fast, works well when only limited information is needed.

*A 5-minute call asking current owners about their next upgrade.*

**Mail**

Low-cost reach, but slow and response rates aren't guaranteed.

*A mailed satisfaction survey to registered warranty owners.*

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## DETERMINE SAMPLING DESIGN & SIZE

### Who do you actually ask?

**EXAMPLE**

**1,200**

smartphone owners, aged 18–45, in cities where the foldable would launch first

*Chosen via stratified random sampling so budget tiers, age groups, and cities are all fairly represented.*

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## COLLECT THE DATA

# Where good plans meet the field

**EXAMPLE**

*Field teams run in-store intercept interviews and phone follow-ups across 6 cities over 3 weeks, with a supervisor reviewing 10% of interviews daily for quality.*

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## ANALYZE & INTERPRET THE DATA

# Turning raw responses into answers

*Edit → code → tabulate: errors get corrected, responses become numbers or symbols (logged in a codebook), then counted.*

### 1 Cross tabulation

*Do foldable-phone purchase intentions differ by age group and income bracket?*

### 2 Conjoint analysis

*Do buyers value a lighter hinge more than a lower price?*

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## PREPARE THE RESEARCH REPORT

### Findings only count once they're communicated

Written with objectivity, clarity, and supporting charts — the report typically includes:

- ✓ Authorization letter
- ✓ Table of contents
- ✓ Executive summary
- ✓ Research objectives
- ✓ Methodology
- ✓ Results
- ✓ Limitations
- ✓ Conclusions & recommendations
- ✓ Appendices (questionnaires, etc.)

**Closing the loop:** the foldable-phone report might conclude “proceed at a mid-tier price point, targeting buyers 25–40” — and flag hinge durability as an area needing further study.

BRINGING IT TOGETHER

# Systematic. Analytical. Objective.

Done this way, marketing research reduces uncertainty and raises both the probability and the size of a decision's success. Each of the eight steps leans on the one before it — which is exactly why skipping ahead rarely pays off.

| 1 | 2 | 3 | 4 | 5 | 6 | 7 | 8 |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| Define | Design | Data & sources | Collection forms | Sampling | Collect | Analyze | Report |